ThoughtfulIndia — 10 Articles | March 2026

Best of global news. Indian perspective. No shouting.

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1. We're Back

March 8, 2026

We went quiet for a while. Not because there was nothing to say — if anything, there was too much. The noise became deafening: every headline a crisis, every tweet a catastrophe, every election the end of something. It became hard to think clearly.

So we stopped, and we watched.

What we saw in the months since was this: India is moving faster than its commentators can process. The world's power structure is shifting in ways that most analysts are only beginning to map. And the thoughtful Indian — the person who wants to understand what's actually happening, not just be outraged about it — is being underserved.

That's the gap we exist to fill.

We are not a news aggregator. We are not a political mouthpiece. We do not have a party, a patron, or an agenda. What we have is a point of view: that India's story is one of the most important stories in the world right now, and it deserves to be told with rigour, context, and honesty.

The world is changing fast. India is at the centre of several of the most important changes. The next few years will determine a great deal about where this country lands — economically, geopolitically, socially.

We're back to help you make sense of it.

Welcome back to ThoughtfulIndia.

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2. Oil at $110: The Number Nobody in India Is Running

March 8, 2026

Oil crossed $110 a barrel today on fears of an Iranian military escalation in the Strait of Hormuz. Financial markets gyrated. The rupee slipped. Traders on Dalal Street reached for their calculators.

But here is the number that most of India's financial media will not tell you, at least not prominently: every $10 rise in crude oil prices costs India approximately $15 billion per year in additional import costs. At $110 a barrel — up from roughly $75 just eight months ago — India is absorbing an import shock of roughly $50 billion annually compared to where it was last year.

That is not a rounding error. That is approximately 1.4% of India's GDP, gone.

India imports roughly 85% of its crude oil. It has no meaningful strategic reserve to buffer a sustained price shock. And while the Reserve Bank of India is fully capable of managing rupee volatility — and has demonstrated this repeatedly — it cannot conjure barrels of oil from thin air.

The RBI can defend the currency. It cannot defend the current account.

The deeper problem is structural and has been for decades: India's economy runs on oil it does not produce, and every time the Middle East catches fire, the bill arrives in Mumbai, Delhi, and every petrol pump in between.

There are solutions, and India has been pursuing them — renewables investment has accelerated sharply, electric vehicle adoption is rising, the push for green hydrogen has real political backing. But these are decade-long transitions. Today, in March 2026, with oil at $110, the economy is exposed.

What India needs — and does not currently have — is a serious public conversation about energy security. Not as an environmental issue, not as a subsidy question, but as a hard national security matter. When the price of oil can transfer 1.5% of your GDP to Gulf exporters in a single year, that is a vulnerability. It deserves to be treated as one.

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3. Trump's Tariff War Is Chaos. For India, It Might Be an Opportunity.

March 8, 2026

Donald Trump's tariff regime is many things. Coherent is not one of them. But amid the chaos, a pattern is emerging — and it is one that India would be foolish to ignore.

The countries bearing the heaviest tariff burden are, almost entirely, the countries that had built their manufacturing base on cheap labour and export-led growth: China, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Mexico. These are the nations that spent the last three decades becoming the world's suppliers of electronics, textiles, pharmaceuticals, and consumer goods. They are now discovering that the US market they built their economies around has decided to charge them extra for the privilege of access.

India sits in an unusual position in this landscape.

Indian exports face a 26% tariff under the current US schedule — high, but lower than the effective rates facing China (above 60% for many categories), Vietnam (46%), and Bangladesh (37%). More importantly, India has something the others largely do not: a services economy capable of absorbing US corporate demand for knowledge work, back-office operations, and increasingly, AI-adjacent technical services.

The opportunity, if India moves to capture it, is significant. American companies that built supply chains through Vietnam and China are actively looking for alternatives. India has the workforce, the legal system, the English language, and — critically — a government that has signalled willingness to negotiate bilateral trade terms with Washington.

The problem is execution speed. India has a long and painful history of letting manufacturing opportunities slip through administrative fingers. Land acquisition, labour laws, port infrastructure, power supply — the familiar litany of obstacles has deterred factory investment for decades while competitors moved faster.

This time, the window may be shorter. Vietnam is already negotiating its way back into US favour. Bangladesh is lobbying hard. Malaysia is positioning itself as an alternative electronics hub.

India has perhaps 18 months to make credible moves. Whether Delhi is capable of that kind of urgency is, to put it diplomatically, an open question.

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4. Stop Measuring India Against a China That No Longer Exists

March 8, 2026

For twenty years, the standard frame for evaluating India's economic progress was the China comparison. How does India's GDP growth compare to China's? How does Indian manufacturing stack up against Chinese manufacturing? Why can't India build infrastructure as fast as China?

It was a reasonable benchmark — for a while. China's rise was the economic story of the early 21st century, and comparing India to it was a way of taking both countries seriously.

But the China being used as a benchmark today is not the China that actually exists in 2026.

The real China in 2026 is a country facing a demographic crisis that its own government describes as existential. The working-age population is shrinking. The one-child policy's consequences are arriving in full. The youth unemployment rate, which the government briefly stopped publishing because the numbers were embarrassing, has been running above 20% for over a year. The real estate sector — which at its peak accounted for roughly 25% of GDP — is still working through the wreckage of the Evergrande collapse and its aftershocks. Private sector investment has been structurally suppressed by years of regulatory unpredictability. Tech entrepreneurs have learned that success makes you a target.

None of this means China is collapsing. It remains a manufacturing superpower, a technological competitor in several critical areas, and a formidable diplomatic actor. But the China of 9% annual GDP growth, seemingly limitless investment capacity, and an unstoppable manufacturing juggernaut — that China is gone.

India should stop measuring itself against it.

The more useful comparison is forward-looking: not where China was, but where India wants to be in 2040. What kind of economy, what kind of society, what kind of global role? Those are the questions worth asking. The answer is unlikely to look like China in 2005, and that should be considered a feature, not a bug.

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5. India's Soft Power Moment Is Happening Without India

March 8, 2026

Something remarkable is occurring, and it has almost nothing to do with any Indian government policy.

Across the world, people who have never been to India and have no particular connection to the subcontinent are learning yoga. They are adding turmeric to their morning routines. They are watching Indian films — not just in the diaspora, but in Brazil, Nigeria, South Korea, and rural France. Ayurveda apps are being downloaded in Barcelona and São Paulo. Meditation practices rooted in Indian philosophy are being taught in American corporate boardrooms and British primary schools.

India's soft power is having a moment. And India, as a state, had almost nothing to do with it.

This is not entirely surprising. The most durable soft power is never manufactured. It emerges organically, carried by culture, diaspora, and the sheer force of ideas that resonate across boundaries. American soft power was not invented by the State Department — it arrived through Hollywood, jazz, and blue jeans. British soft power travels on the English language and the Premier League. Indian soft power, it turns out, travels on wellness, spirituality, and the growing global appetite for alternatives to the materialist mainstream.

The opportunity this creates for India is enormous. A world that is already culturally curious about India is a world that is more likely to invest in India, trade with India, and align politically with India. Soft power is not separate from hard interests — it is their precondition.

What India lacks is any coherent strategy to convert this cultural moment into lasting influence. The government's existing soft power apparatus — ICCR cultural centres, yoga day proclamations, the occasional film festival — is episodic and underfunded. There is no Indian equivalent of the British Council, no systematic effort to build on what is already happening organically.

India is sitting on a soft power windfall it has not yet learned to spend.

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6. The Trillion-Dollar Talent Corridor Nobody Is Building

March 8, 2026

India produces approximately 1.5 million engineering graduates every year. The United States, in the middle of an artificial intelligence arms race that is reshaping every industry, cannot find enough technical talent to fill the roles being created.

This is not a new observation. The India-US technology talent corridor has existed for forty years. It produced the wave of Indian-origin executives who now run a remarkable proportion of America's largest technology companies. It has been one of the more consequential demographic-economic phenomena of the late 20th century.

What is new is the scale of the current moment.

The AI transition is not like previous technology cycles. It is not creating demand for one category of technical worker — it is creating demand across the entire technology stack, from fundamental research to applied engineering to operations and deployment. American universities are producing nowhere near enough people with the relevant skills. American immigration policy, for all its occasional lurches toward reform, remains a bottleneck. And American companies are increasingly willing to hire remote international talent rather than wait.

India should be the primary beneficiary of this dynamic. In many ways, it already is — Indian engineers are well-represented in AI research labs and technology companies globally. But the opportunity to formalise and accelerate this corridor, to build institutions and policies that capture its full value, remains largely unseized.

On the American side, the political obstacles are real. Talent immigration is caught in a broader immigration debate that has little to do with economic rationality. On the Indian side, the policy apparatus for managing the talent corridor is surprisingly thin — more reactive than strategic, more focused on remittances than on building lasting institutional relationships.

A serious bilateral initiative on talent mobility could be worth trillions of dollars in economic value over the next two decades. No government on either side has yet decided to build it.

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7. On the Selective Outrage About Indian Democracy

March 8, 2026

Criticism of Indian democracy is legitimate. India is a democracy, and democracies are supposed to be criticised. The press should scrutinise power. Civil society should challenge authority. International observers should apply consistent standards.

The problem is the consistency.

Over the past few years, a pattern has emerged in the commentary on India from certain Western media outlets and human rights organisations that is worth naming directly. India receives intensive, sustained scrutiny on issues of press freedom, minority rights, and electoral integrity. These are genuine issues that deserve genuine attention. But they are applied to India with a rigour and a relentlessness that is conspicuously absent when the same observers discuss other countries in the region.

Pakistan's military has removed or undermined elected governments repeatedly, most recently in circumstances that attracted minimal sustained criticism from the same voices that write thousands of words about India's democratic backsliding. Bangladesh witnessed episodes of mob justice and targeted violence against minorities that received a fraction of the coverage given to comparable incidents in India. Sri Lanka's economic collapse, driven by governance failures of spectacular magnitude, was treated as a technocratic story rather than a democratic accountability story. And China — a country that has imprisoned over a million Uyghurs in what credible independent investigators describe as a system of mass detention — receives, from some of the loudest critics of India, a kind of resigned strategic tolerance that is not extended to New Delhi.

This is not an argument that India's problems should go unscrutinised. They should be scrutinised, rigorously and without favour.

It is an argument that selective outrage is not the same as principled criticism. When the standards applied to a country are determined more by its geopolitical alignment than by the actual severity of its human rights situation, the result is not journalism or advocacy — it is politics by other means.

India deserves better critics. The kind who apply consistent standards. Those critics exist, and their work is valuable. They are just not always the loudest voices in the room.

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8. The Rupee at 87: What the Panic Gets Wrong

March 8, 2026

Every time the rupee falls to a new low against the dollar, a certain kind of commentary follows. Editorials warn of crisis. Opposition politicians demand explanations. Financial television fills its airtime with analysts predicting further falls. The impression created is of an economy losing control of its currency.

This impression is, for the most part, wrong.

The rupee's movement to around 87 to the dollar is not a crisis. It is a managed depreciation, and it is one the Reserve Bank of India has been engineering — carefully, deliberately, and for defensible reasons.

Here is the context that most of the panic commentary omits: India's inflation differential with the United States over the past five years has been approximately 2-3% per year. All else being equal, a currency should depreciate by approximately that differential to maintain real exchange rate stability. The rupee has depreciated by roughly that amount. This is not a failure — it is how currency adjustment is supposed to work.

The RBI has, if anything, been intervening to slow the rupee's depreciation, not speed it up. India's foreign exchange reserves remain substantial — over $600 billion at last count — providing ample buffer against speculative attacks. The central bank has the tools, the experience, and the institutional credibility to manage the currency through periods of global volatility.

None of this means the rupee's level is irrelevant. A weaker rupee makes imports more expensive — including, critically, the oil discussed elsewhere in this issue. It affects the cost of foreign-currency debt. It has distributional consequences.

But the rupee's exchange rate is a symptom, not the disease. The underlying challenge for India is not the currency — it is the trade structure. India runs persistent current account deficits because it imports more than it exports. The solution to that is to build an export base capable of generating the foreign exchange earnings that reduce the structural pressure on the rupee.

Fix exports. The currency problem becomes more manageable. That is the conversation worth having.

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9. India's Education Blindspot

March 8, 2026

IIT Bombay's latest ranking in the QS World University Rankings prompted the usual round of pride and commentary. India's premier technical institutions are world-class — everyone knows this. The IITs produce graduates who go on to lead technology companies, research laboratories, and government agencies across the world. The IIMs produce managers who run some of the most complex organisations on the planet.

The problem is the number.

The IITs collectively admit approximately 16,000 students per year across all their undergraduate programmes. The IIMs admit roughly 4,000 students per year across their flagship management programmes. These are rounding errors against the scale of India's higher education system, which enrolls approximately 43 million students annually.

Those 43 million students are, overwhelmingly, enrolled in institutions that receive a small fraction of the attention, funding, and reform energy directed at the premier institutions. India's 900-plus state universities and 40,000-plus affiliated colleges are chronically underfunded. Faculty positions go unfilled for years. Research infrastructure is minimal. Political interference in academic governance is endemic. The curriculum in many institutions has not been substantively updated in decades.

The result is a higher education system that is excellent at the very top and deeply inadequate through most of its breadth. It produces a small cohort of graduates who are genuinely competitive globally, and a vastly larger cohort who emerge from university with degrees that certify little and skills that are poorly matched to what an evolving economy actually needs.

This is not simply an education problem. It is an economic problem, a social mobility problem, and ultimately a political problem. The students who cannot get into IIT or IIM — which is to say, the overwhelming majority of Indian students — deserve institutions capable of giving them a genuine foothold in the economy.

The investment required to transform India's state university system is large but not impossible. What has been missing, for decades, is the political will to prioritise it.

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10. Five Things Reshaping India's World That We're Not Talking About

March 8, 2026

India is at an inflection point. Several forces are converging simultaneously — some representing genuine opportunities, others serious risks. Most are being discussed, if at all, in fragments rather than as the interconnected set of challenges and chances that they actually represent.

Here are five of them.

The Gulf equation is changing. Saudi Arabia and the UAE are diversifying their economies, deepening ties with China, and reconsidering the alignments that defined the post-1973 oil order. For India, whose relationship with the Gulf is deep — built on decades of labour migration, remittances, and energy dependence — this is a significant shift. The 8-9 million Indians working in Gulf countries send home roughly $40 billion a year. That flow is not going away soon, but its long-term stability depends on Gulf economic conditions that are themselves in flux.

The China+1 supply chain shift is real but slow. Multinational companies have been talking about diversifying away from China since the trade war began in 2018. Actual diversification has happened, but more slowly and selectively than the headlines suggest. India has captured some of it — Apple's expansion of iPhone manufacturing in India is the most visible example. But the bulk of the shift has gone to Vietnam, Mexico, and other locations with faster regulatory environments and better infrastructure. India needs to make the remaining window count.

The climate bill is arriving. India has committed to ambitious climate targets, and the transition to renewable energy is genuinely underway. But the costs of climate change itself — extreme heat, irregular monsoons, coastal flooding — are also arriving, and they fall disproportionately on the poor. The political economy of climate in India is more complex than the international conversation acknowledges.

Digital public infrastructure is India's most underappreciated export. UPI, Aadhaar, the Account Aggregator framework — India has built a set of digital infrastructure layers that most of the developing world is now looking at closely. This is both genuine soft power and a potential source of technical and commercial influence that has barely been tapped.

The diaspora dividend is underutilised. Indian-origin people hold senior positions in government, technology, medicine, and finance in the United States, United Kingdom, Canada, and Australia. The question of how India converts that presence into durable institutional relationships — beyond pride — remains largely unanswered. Other countries have thought harder about this. India should too.

These are not the only stories. But they are among the most important ones. We will be returning to all of them.